

The Book of the Dead Man (Writing the Dead Man Poem)

1. Writing the Dead Man Poem

When the dead man writes a poem, he immediately writes another one.
He writes another because two follows one.
So well does part two shadow part one that they cannot help but argue
and marry.
He who would write a dead man poem must know that all things coalesce.
She who writes a dead woman poem must understand that perception is
kaleidoscopic.
The dead man sees and hears every tangent, every approach, every blade of
grass that bows this way then that.
When the dead man repeats himself, he never steps into the same line twice.
The dead man, after midnight, turns the key that coils his insides.
His poem lasts as long as his innermost spring remains compacted.
When the dead man's spring snaps outward and bites, then the poem has
ended that defined the moment.
A dead man poem knows that the sentence is the key.
The sentence, sans enjambments, has redefined free verse.
Yet it is not the sentencing on the page alone but the sentence of time.
The dead man serves the sentence, he fluctuates between the long and
short of it, between the finite and the infinite, between the millisecond
and eternity.
Whosoever shall write a dead man poem must know in his bones that his
lifetime is an event that splits another event in two.
That is why a dead man poem must have two parts.
You may think at any moment you are done with life—so many first
thoughts, so many smarts, such agility—but you are not.
Later, you may think you had only begun at the finish, so complete was your
escape from time while writing the dead man poem.
You may be discordant or discombobulated or delighted to feel the weight
of a dead man poem.

For a dead man poem threads and disentangles, sews and slices, glues and fractures.

Its harmonies are made of missing notes and from words he would gladly take back.

It is in the dead man's mission to show up the illusions of time, the discrete, chaos, order, health, and whosoever misuses quantum mechanics one day and the death of armies the next.

Write a dead man poem if you must, but only if you must.

For the dead man hath no choice, he hath only blind luck and love.

He hath only his prophetic existentialism, his diary of the posthumous.

The true dead man book can be opened anywhere to the fullness of life, what else was poetry ever for?

2. More About Writing the Dead Man Poem

It is also necessary to understand the abandonment of distinctions.

To realize that a poem can be forbidding yet ephemeral, while a dead man poem may run from side to side or seesaw yet carry the gravity of the ancient.

Why this is so is of a matter embedded in mortality.

So deeply buried that vanity cannot mine it, it will take poetry masquerading as prose, philosophy hiding in the impulsive, the devil-take-the-hindsight, shotgun-riding, seat-of-the-pants voice of the very now without regard for itself to express the consolations of time, and to say for once the solace Jacob felt wrestling the angel.

Do I surprise you with my reference, very well then, I surprise you.

I invite you now to write the dead man poem, the dead woman poem, the poem of the dead chorus fluttering the weeds with song.

For only then will you be one among the many, your intentions subsumed in something larger than the self.

Your sentences must be elastic, your thoughts flexible, your heart given to the hidden acrobatics of dark emotions.

That is all I can tell you.

To help you any more than this would be like the rain instructing a cloud—too late, too late.

The dead man is plugged in, he is the last vestiges of dead friends, he suffers the little children to grow up and away.

He hath lasted the lashing of night, he hath wrestled the angel to a draw.

Few will know how lasting his love.

For you cannot write a dead man poem if you have not known love.